

What It Looks Like When You Don't Know You're Trauma Bonded

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I am going to tell a story about a client of mine. I am keeping the de
her privacy.

If someone had told her she was trauma bonded, she wouldn't have
That was actually the first thing she said to me when we spoke.
was just deeply in love with someone complicated and she was tryin
She thought it was just a matter of learning how to communicate b



But when we got on our first call, it was very clear she was being en
and then gaslit to her into believing it was connection.

She was trauma bonded, and like most survivors, she had no ide

I won't sugarcoat it—this journey isn't clean or easy. It's messy and brutal, and there will be days when you feel like you're making no progress at all.

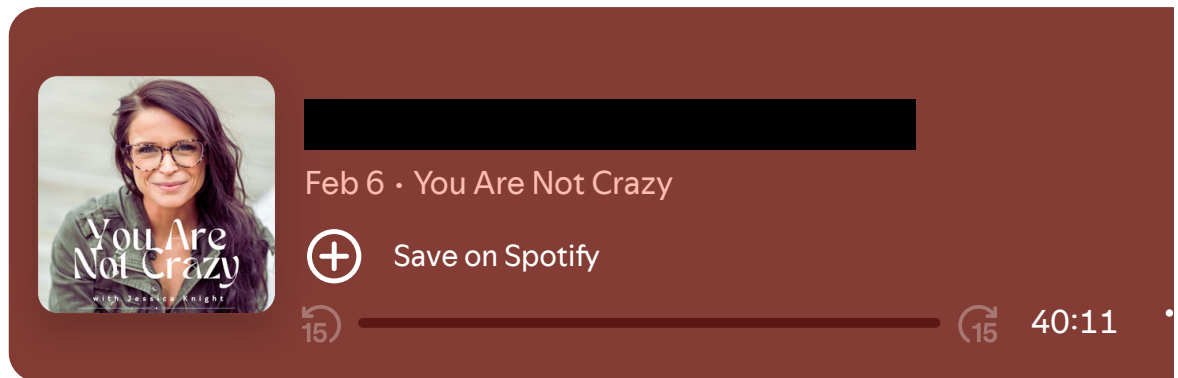
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What is a trauma bond?

A trauma bond is a psychological attachment to someone who *hurt*

intermittently soothes you. It forms when your nervous system can't regulate intimacy. When love gets tangled with fear, and safety becomes confusion.

This is a very limited description of a very complex thing. **You can find more on this here:**



This is how it showed up in her story:

- She tried to leave, more than once. He always pulled her back with promises (but she really believed them).
- He gave her just enough hope to stay confused, but never enough to leave. She blamed herself.
- He crossed sexual boundaries and said the most tender things and told her not to take anything he said seriously.
- He refused to call it a relationship. Then asked to remain close. When she set boundaries around it and kept pursuing the “relationship”

- He went silent for weeks, then reappeared like nothing happened
- He told her she wasn't the love of his life, but that she was radiant. That she was unhealthy, but amazing. That she failed him, but moved ahead.

She didn't call it abuse. She said she felt confused and that she didn't know where the boundary was anymore. **She said she couldn't stop thinking about building a new life for herself.**

That's a trauma bond.

I work with clients on all stages of a trauma bond. **You might be trapped**

- You feel more anxious than safe in the connection.
- You constantly try to decode their words, moods, or silence.
- You blame yourself for the hurt they caused.
- You try to earn love through self-abandonment.
- You stay loyal to their *potential*, even when their reality is harsh.
- You feel addicted to the highs—and devastated by the lows.
- You minimize red flags because of how strong the pull feels.
- You feel ashamed for still caring.

It's so hard to see when you're in it because trauma bonds don't :
They start with chemistry, charm and vulnerability. They make it se
“get” you. You become attached and stuck to the feeling that maybe
person who sees your soul.

Then things shift—slowly. Boundaries blur. Clarity disappears. **You**
doing the emotional labor. You begin to feel like the problem.

You don't even realize that your nervous system has fused intim
instability.

You start working harder—trying to fix what you didn't break and g
it was.” You keep trying to keep the peace. **Until one day you reali**
the one holding all the weight, carrying the emotion and taking

And underneath it all, your nervous system is being rewired—witho
You crave their comfort in the very moments they're hurting you, b
trained you to believe relief *only* comes from them.

You stop asking: “Is this healthy?”

You start asking: “How do I get back to the version of them that ma

That's the trap. You're not chasing love. You're chasing emotional r
You're chasing the version of them that never really existed—at
way you needed them to.

And that's why it's so hard to leave. Because your body got hooked and the calm would return if you could just hold on a little longer.

If you're starting to unhook, I'm here to help

I created [Unhooked](#) — a private podcast series and course companion for people who are still stuck in the loop:

The missing. The minimizing. The shame. The exhaustion.

In it, we map the cycle of abuse, explore what makes it so addictive, and the slow, powerful process of reclaiming your clarity, your dignity, and

Listen to Unhooked: <https://jessicaknight.thinkific.com/courses/unhooked>

You don't have to keep reliving the pain to understand it.

And you don't have to keep waiting for them to give you peace.



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